Eric Zelman - **04:16**

Sa. It. Hi, Jen. How are you?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **05:12**

Hey. How are you doing?

Eric Zelman - **05:13**

I'm well. I'm well.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **05:14**

You look great. You look great. You're in Rhode island, right?

Eric Zelman - **05:18**

Yeah, yeah. So, yeah, I'm in Providence and.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **05:24**

Very nice. Very nice.

Eric Zelman - **05:26**

Nothing has changed.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **05:28**

Nothing. I wasn't sure. I wasn't sure. I'm like, if my memory serves me, I believe he's in Rhode island, but I wasn't sure. Excellent. Excellent. And you. And have you been working with David on. I don't meant. I met with David a few weeks ago and he mentioned that he was chatting with you or maybe I'm mistaken.

Eric Zelman - **05:47**

No, no. I mean, I do keep in touch with David because, you know, I just kind of interested in what he's doing and.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **05:53**

Yeah, absolutely.

Eric Zelman - **05:54**

And then, you know, recently, and one of the reasons I wanted to reach out to you is I've been sort of bringing up this project that I thought that he might have some insight into.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **06:03**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **06:04**

Of best practices or just understanding, you know, is it viable? And so I was looking for some of his. His feedback and his validation on some of my ideas, and I love it. I met with him a couple of days ago and it was. And we had a really interesting conversation, and he was like, you absolutely should talk to Jen. And I'm like, I know. And, you know, I'll be quite honest, I think I was just. I know that, like, talking to people and culture people and HR people is sort of like, the thing that I need to do. And I needed him to push me, to say, go do it.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **06:34**

Yeah, no, for sure. And you know what? Like, I'll be honest with you, like, he kind of shared with me and it. And he said, you know, I. Like, he's like, I'm. And what I love about David Keane is he genuinely wants to try to help his people who are displaced. And. And I just feel so grateful. Like, he and I met probably, I guess maybe it's a month ago now, I don't know, a few weeks ago, and I helped him with ideas for the HR module, with his platform, and kind of gave, like, helped him, like, just basically just what he should be including. And then I wrote an article and we kind of hope would have gotten more traction and maybe, like, maybe drove more business to him, but ultimately, maybe it's just still in its early stages. But I do.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **07:15**

I do love the fact that he does try to help anyone and everyone who's ever been impacted by a reduction, you know? You know, whether it be with the showpad involvement or with the private equity take private or some of the other reductions in force we've had over the years, which absolutely stinks. But I, I also, I've been following some of your posts and you have such a valid point. Like I, I just actually I interviewed two weeks ago for a startup company called Familiar Machines and what it's a spin off of iRobot. Like basically some of the execs from IROBOT are now starting a new company and ultimately like the recruiter, it was an in house recruiter. They contacted me. You're a great fit for this role. Gave them my salary expectations. I'm thinking, I'm saying to my husband like this is great.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **08:02**

Like I love this. It's a startup but they can meet, you know, meet myself. They told me an ideal fit and then like a follow up, follow up. Finally like last night I'm like this is crazy. It was two weeks from yesterday that I had interviewed with the initial with the recruiter and the feed. The feedback I got was excellent. Except they were, she was like I, I'm sorry at this stage in Familiar Machines, you know, at this stage because they were just getting series A funding. We can't afford your base ask. Right. And that's all good and fine and I, I, but my guess is it was significantly lower. But she maybe didn't know that. But it's still strange. I don't know. So you don't know what to believe. Right? Like where it was. It's just, it's very frustrating.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **08:43**

So I'm kind of exploring fractional stuff as opposed to direct full time.

Eric Zelman - **08:49**

Me too, me too. Absolutely. I'm looking just for anything. So I kind of started building this project as kind of a life raft because I realized that, you know, I'm 55 and I'm right one year behind.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **09:01**

You, my friend again.

Eric Zelman - **09:02**

And, and I, I shaved the beard because I was like nervous it was making me look any older than I am and I just feel like I'm just, I'm not, I'm not getting traction. I've had 140 applications, some of more earnest than others and get it, you know, I've had five or six interviews and some have been really good and then you know, things just sort of like evaporate. Some people are like and so, so let me give you the pitch and oh and by the way, you're in Florida. So your parents are in Florida.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **09:31**

No, I'm not. So I Have to tell you what ended up happening. I was supposed to go to Florida, right? Just quickly. And I saw, I got, I looked on the weather app just to kind of see how to pack. And it showed, like, it said, ponding torrential rains, 98% rain every single day this week except for Monday night when I was flying down. And I'm like, I said, I've been down twice to see them. And I thought it was opportunity. It was a great opportunity because they come back up to the North Shore in Boston area, but in the end of the month. But I said, mom, I said, I love you, I want to see you. But I am not sitting in that condo for like 12 hours a day watching Netflix and reading because I can't do it.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **10:10**

And she's like, I totally get it. So I didn't end up going.

Eric Zelman - **10:13**

I, I, I, I, I totally relate to that. I mean, my wife's parents live in, on the west coast of Florida, like just north of Naples. And it's, and it's great. And they don't have a condo. So I mean, I can't complain when I visit them or whatever, but it is the kind of thing if you're stuck inside all day down there.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **10:34**

I just, I couldn't do it because as is, I've been, I'm sure you have to, Eric. I've been going through all these emotions of like, I'll be very transparent with you and tell you, like, there's days that I'm like, crying and I'm like, why? Like, why? Like, it's just, it's been a, I've been a mess because I need to work. Like, not, I don't. Obviously we all need to work to make ends meet, but I mean, I need to work mentally, too. I can't just. Because then I hear people saying, well, why don't you retire? And I'm like, retire? I'm 54 years old.

Eric Zelman - **11:02**

Okay, so maybe I've hit you at the right time to ask you about my project because, yes, I, I'm hopeful that it resonates with you. Okay, so let me go to a quick slide.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **11:13**

Jack, go right ahead. Yeah, I'm going to put on my glasses so I can see it and I.

Eric Zelman - **11:20**

All right, so where are we here?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **11:22**

But your posts have been resonating with me, so I have a feeling this will.

Eric Zelman - **11:26**

Well, you know, my LinkedIn post. I'll just tell you that part, I mean, there's a big part of me that hates LinkedIn. And so part of this. So, so let me explain. So when Vector came in, I hired a, a very senior C level, former C level VP person as a career coach and someone who was more of the Persona. Not like that he was Bob. I don't know Bob that well, but of someone who had been through those kinds of things. And I was looking for career coaching to try to survive. Right. Because you know, you've known me, I built, I became the sort of organic molecule within Big Tin can. And I'd worked with Pat for a long time.

Eric Zelman - **12:14**

So as I said to David, it's like, yeah, I know how to navigate a world where it's like, you know, argue with Pat and David for something I need or advocate or however you want to spin it. But in a world of Vector that was just completely outside of it was off the table. Right. And I had to kind of try to figure out. I wanted to salvage what I could or not salvage, but just, buttress and survive and obviously here we are. So that experience and then a follow up experience with another career coach who was very different from that led me to sort of have this.

Eric Zelman - **12:50**

I mean, you know, it's going to sound trite, maybe like this midlife epiphany, but that there is a need and for some way for someone who's been heads down for 15 years in their job to find a deeper through line in articulating who they are, what they want and where they want to go in their career and.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **13:15**

Absolutely.

Eric Zelman - **13:16**

And you know, I'll be completely transparent that along the way of doing this I had a lot of revelations about things that I in the past had dismissed that now I was coming to sort of appreciate. So I knew by maybe, and this took me a while, but I knew that I wanted to, you know, persist in the sort of customer journey space and maybe focus more on customer success. Because that's originally what I was doing at Pigt and Can before I started doing support. And I knew that I wanted to be in this very primordial early stage startup and I knew that I wanted to do that and I knew that also those aren't jobs that get posted because they don't exist yet. So I had to figure out how do I reach out to founders and how do I find them?

Eric Zelman - **14:05**

How do I find the next big Tin can where I can be part of that first, that 20, 40 people.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **14:12**

Yep.

Eric Zelman - **14:12**

Yeah. And, and again, it's messy. In that really tiny atomic layer, you do everything. And so, you know, for me and my resume, it's sort of like, yeah, I wear many hats. Right. And that's. And that's also right now, a difficult place to be. I mean, for a lot of reasons, everyone's like, wants experts, and I get it.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **14:33**

So I do.

Eric Zelman - **14:35**

Yeah. So I started to realize that the tools that are out there for me to do job searching and just career development just really were just. They were like, okay, here's where you can track your resume, and here's this dummy AI bot that'll teach you how to, you know, ats, optimize your resume. And this isn't helping me. Right. You know, like playing bingo with applications. A, you know, keyword bingo is.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **15:02**

It's so true.

Eric Zelman - **15:03**

It's garbage. It's just garbage. And, And I don't. It wasn't helping me or, I mean, to date, you know, it hasn't helped me.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **15:11**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **15:11**

And. And I think that there's got to be a better way to this. So. So what I started to conceptualize was more of a portfolio document, a structured text document that synthesized all of these different materials that I brought to it. So it wasn't just like my resume. It was things like disc assessments. And, you know, I. And you're familiar with those, I'm sure.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **15:37**

Yes, absolutely. I mean, we used my gosh PI at Big Tin can, but absolutely. Yes.

Eric Zelman - **15:44**

Yeah. Yeah. And so, I mean, I remember that. And so I know that I can tell you, and this is probably the case for most people, at least this is my. My gut here is that most people probably, when they take those tests, just game them to what they think that the, you know, the shop wants. What. What is going to make them look good. And so it doesn't really get at the core of who they are and kind of what their values are. I'm just going to move this over so that it looks like instead of your face on that side of the screen, it's right in front of the camera. So I want.

Eric Zelman - **16:15**

So I realized that when I did a disc assessment with this second, with this first coach, about two months after leaving Picton can, when I was in this kind of discovery, not necessarily vulnerable, but kind of just more open state. The disc assessment and his consequential scoring was scarily like me. I mean, it was like 80 or 90% like me.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **16:39**

And I was interesting.

Eric Zelman - **16:41**

I was amazed because I've never had. I've done three of them prior. And I mean, you know, we've all done a lot of these things. And, you know, you. You can get different experiences and different results from them. And it's also a lot, I think. I, I think at his point, I don't know if you concur with this, but it also is a lot about the person who's scoring the test. I mean, and you can do it in different ways. So he's been doing this for a couple of decades and he's very, he's great at it.

Eric Zelman - **17:10**

But so from all these materials, I started to think about how could I create a sort of blended document that helps me to understand not only who I am, but then that I could take that document and start to apply it as a overlay, or in this case, we'll call it a lens over companies and opportunities. And so I built a kind of SDR pipeline, if you will, for jobs. And for starters. So I, you know, I knew that I wanted to work for Early Stage. I knew I was going to find these jobs in LinkedIn or Indeed or any of that crap. And I know that, you know, how do I find these companies? So I started to create basically a bunch of AI agents that do things like enrichment and scraping of VC portfolios.

Eric Zelman - **18:00**

And so along the way to this point, I've scraped probably, I don't know, like 4,000 startups. And what I do with those is I use this lens as a guide to understand do I fit them, like, what sector are they in, what's their customer Persona, what, how many people do they have, what stage of funding, you know, what's their funding like? Are they PE backed in any way? You know, who are the founders, what are, you know, are there through lines between my experience and what they need? And are they at that point of inflection where they're past the point or they're at the point really of thinking we need someone to handle customers because the founder needs to get out of the way.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **18:42**

Exactly right.

Eric Zelman - **18:44**

And that's a lot. And I don't think that from what I've seen, there weren't any other ways of doing this. It's sort of like a DIY thing and it speaks to, you know, I think what your post with David was about, which is, you know, that this is, we're going to live in this diy, build it yourself world. But the part that I think is novel about this isn't the scraper, it isn't the I found 4000 startups or any of that. It's the part that I think that is the moat that I was saying to David is the idea of a lens and the idea that there can be a candidate lens.

Eric Zelman - **19:18**

And one of the things I started talking with coaches about and I was exploring, and what I want to talk to you about is the idea of beyond this way of sort of having an AI chatbot spend 45 minutes with you fleshing out your personality. And I trained it on the coaching materials that I have. Right. From months ago.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **19:38**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **19:39**

So it has that coach voice and the discovery process. But. But what I'm getting at here is that I think that for hirers, if you get 1000 resumes and 800 of them have been bingoed. Right. And now you have, you know, 800 possible people that you have to filter. Right. How do you narrow that down to the people that you really want to talk to?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **20:11**

Right. It's tricky. Right. Because that's a significant amount.

Eric Zelman - **20:16**

Yeah. And maybe it's not 800, maybe it's 200. But I think that regardless. Right, right. I think that the opportunity here is to be able to create a structured document that isn't just the JD but that is the sort of values, working style, personalities, the dynamics of not just what you want the person to be in the role, but the people they're going to work with to figure out is this a fit. You know, when Louis and I would interview people and I would. I was very collaborative with this. I mean, some people aren't like this. Right. Like, I. He's going to. His ears are burning. Because I use him as an example all the time. Like, Pat doesn't want this tool. Pat is like, I know in five seconds if you're the right person or not, you know?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **21:08**

Right. But does he know? Like, I get it, but I still think sometimes. Yeah, I guess that's a good way to gauge. But go ahead. I'm sorry, Go ahead.

Eric Zelman - **21:17**

Yeah. No, I mean, and their personalities like that, just different.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **21:20**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **21:21**

Yeah. But Lewis and I would spend all this time sort of just tag teaming these, these interviews. And I was doing it also because I was learning a lot from Lewis because he'd interviewed a lot more people than I had. And, you know, we would try to do these things of like, you know, tell us about, like, you know, things that you're. Your weak points. Right. And, and, you know, Lou, always say to them, and don't say I work too hard, you know, like, just like trying to get down to who they are. And honesty is everything in this. So garbage in, garbage out. But I think that at the company level, if a company can Be transparent about what it knows its weaknesses are internally.

Eric Zelman - **22:01**

It doesn't have to expose those to the employees, but it can use that in concert with AI agents to unearth fit and assessment between the employer and the candidate. And what. And, and again, I'm going off on a limb here, so you could be like, eric, I've seen this for years and this never works. But what I also noticed was that no one was doing this and doing research on competitive landscape like that. This tool as it exists, at least from what I've seen, doesn't, isn't there. It isn't something that's offered by Rippling or, and I know the CEO of Rippling. It's a long story. But, but, or Ashby or, you know, any of that stuff. Right. They're all deep in ats.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **22:47**

Yeah, for sure. Yep, you're right.

Eric Zelman - **22:50**

And so my, my theory is that if I can have a tool that creates a custom. A candidate lens, which is what I'm testing right now, where it's a chat bot where people spend about 45 minutes uploading their resume or their code, or if it's my wife, her images of her graphic design work, so they can understand her style. And it can also figure out, oh, she does annual reports or she does business cards, or she does web design. I mean, you can get all of that from the ingestion, right? And you can flesh all that out. The other thing that happens, by the way, in this is that my model doesn't just sort of take in, hey, here's your through line as pros.

Eric Zelman - **23:32**

But what I did with mine is that and what the, the tool does or can do is build out scoring frameworks. So it knows that I don't want to work for pe. It knows how much I'm, I want to make. It knows what kind of marketing roles I've been in, but what kind of marketing roles I can't do. It knows customer. Yeah. It knows customer Personas that I can support and I haven't. It knows, I mean, it's very, very detailed. And it also has in all of that, those bigger coaching kinds of things like, you know, what's my management style, what's. It has that fit into my identity and sort of my essence about who I am and trying to bridge the personal and private.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **24:15**

Well, that's just it. And I, I think like, I just. You. You hit you. One of your posts resonated with me because I, I've always, I have like 15 years of recruitment experience. Prior to being in like an, in an HR corporate. And one thing I've always said to recruiters, like, and I've always said to hiring managers is you have to sometimes think outside of the resume. Right? Because ultimately like even what you're describing to me, and it does sound like you're nailing it with everything, but I guess so I have a question for you. Devil's advocate question. So Jen Monkowitz has a ton of tech in her background.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **24:49**

Like you, I take this, this, you kind of analyze my background and I take, I have a ton of tech and I don't have any, say, life sciences, but I have all the skills that could basically do the job in a life sciences environment. Like how does it, how do you determine that? Like based upon just drive and personality and work ethic. Like, like how do you sort of. Yeah, I mean, two together.

Eric Zelman - **25:15**

So, so what my system does is that it basically breaks a person's requirements down into like a hundred point scoring system.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **25:25**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **25:25**

So, so there's a lot of tweaking and tuning to this. But it's like saying, hey, if this is so, for instance, I have, I did healthcare marketing for Pet CT and oncology for a few years.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **25:40**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **25:41**

And so I like the idea of going back to healthcare. Not because, I mean healthcare is deeply broken, but I would do it again. Right. I think there's interesting contributions that healthcare can make to the world and you know, and so from a company perspective, I'm looking at it as like, well, what are SaaS B2B health care opportunities? Right. And, but also when it's looking at these portfolio companies saying, you know, what if their customer is a lab manager, right. I don't, that's not me. And if their customer is, you know, potentially, although I could learn it, I mean, I'm not trying to absolutely rule it out, but what happens is that when it sees those things it just knocks off some points. Right? So there, there's all these different weighted perspectives.

Eric Zelman - **26:34**

And the other thing that the system can do is that you can. So I have this concept because of this photography thing, but it doesn't have to play out in the UI like this. But yeah, what it is this idea of if you think about a camera that you can go wide or you can go, you know, wide angle lenses or telephoto, so you can go very wide and something, you can go very narrow on something. And the other idea also is this idea of when you take a Picture. And this is a little bit more conceptual maybe, and I have to flesh this out more so it's clear. But, you know, you can decide that you only want that subject in the foreground to be sharp and you want the background to be blurred like our zoom background.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **27:14**

Right, Right, yep.

Eric Zelman - **27:15**

And that those two things are how. I look at how you can adjust sliders in this system, because if you have five or six variables like energy or values or mission or whatever, you want to sort of frame up this, the system of what Jen is what's important to you.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **27:32**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **27:33**

You can, you can use that as a means of adjusting how it's scoring and how it's looking at the opportunities that's great in the pipeline. And you could do that the other way around with the candidates. So one of the things that I think would be really cool project to build, which I'm maybe in the next week is taking like 100 hypothetical applicants and looking at JD and showing. Being able to show someone how they could zoom in and zoom out on applicants and seeing what the results are. Right. Because you could get really myopic and be like, yes, they have

to have, you know, eight years of this particular engineering skill and that's all I care about. Or you could be looking for something much more general. Right.

Eric Zelman - **28:15**

And I think that's important into a system like this because it's never going to be 100 and it's. And it's kind of like, you know, it's like what David was talking about with me the other day about the difference between keyword searching and vector searching. And so this is a series of vectors. This isn't it. It's. It's AI driven. Or I like to say it's in its ideal form, it's coach driven AI. Right.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **28:39**

Yeah, I'd like to say that I like that better. I agree. Because. Yeah, I mean, tell me, like, speaking of that, like you just hit, like hit something, hit a nerve. I mean, think about it, all of the applications you and I have applied to, Right? Because I'm gonna, I'll be very transparent with you and tell you I think I've applied to like120 on LinkedIn and maybe had five interviews as well that haven't panned out, but that here we are. I get, yeah, I get rejections immediately when, like, which to me an AI agent is basically, or some sort of AI tool is immediately rejecting me without even knowing who I am, knowing my background. It's like it's happening to everybody and anybody. So this is, this concept you have is really, is huge.

Eric Zelman - **29:27**

So, you know, and I've had, I mean, I'm trying to get as much feedback as possible and I don't want to, I don't have much time to have so I could ramble on all day. But yesterday I spoke with my father in law. The beauty of people retiring around in Florida is they meet other people that they, I, you know, of course. So one of his friends that he and his wife have down there is this woman who retired from Goldman Sachs 13 years ago and she led their executive recruiting for 30 years there.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **29:53**

Wow.

Eric Zelman - **29:54**

Yeah. And I was like. So I talked to her yesterday for about half an hour and it was an incredible conversation. But what's funny also about talking to someone who does executive recruiting, Goldman Sachs, even up until 2016 or whatever, is that everyone that she spoke to, his base compensation was like 500,000 and up, of course. So, so.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **30:15**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **30:16**

So what she's so I guess what I'm saying is that I was talking to someone who's basically working in the Lamborghini of this space. And, and by the time that she got someone, you know, they were, they had been vetted. But what she thought was an interesting opportunity for this tool because she couldn't speak to it in terms of like schlumps like me looking for a job at midlife. Because that isn't people, that's not. The people that they have were that she would see attrition at Goldman of young people who had, who were junior partners or hadn't made partner yet. And in that messy space, what they would lose these people to other opportunities. And so I think that this lens idea also has a, maybe has a, an equal or better life as a tool within a company for internal candidates versus.

Eric Zelman - **31:12**

But you've been in recruiting, so I'll let you tell me if that resonates.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **31:19**

No, absolutely, it certainly does. I think it can be an internal tool. But I also think I, I think. Absolutely. I think it's, it's huge for. Are you saying internal mobility?

Eric Zelman - **31:30**

Yeah, I'm saying like if they had, she didn't say if we had the tool we would have, you know, these people wouldn't have left, but that this unknown of these, this cadre of people that they've pulled in from these Ivy League schools who are going to jump to some other company before the age of 30 or 35 or whatever.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **31:50**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **31:50**

You know, and keeping that talent in the company and knowing what to do with people, like where do they, how, you know, who are they, how do we grow them, where should they go? I know we didn't have these luxuries at Big Tin can or I didn't feel like I had these luxuries at Big Ten.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **32:06**

No, we certainly didn't. And that's the thing. Right?

Eric Zelman - **32:10**

So I mean, you know, there's rubber hits the road, but I think for some places there really are those kinds of questions and discovery opportunities something like this could give. Okay, so let me jump out of the slides for a second and show you a bit about how this works for me. Right. So this isn't what I would give to. I'm going to share my screen again in a second. This is not what I would give to other human beings to work with, but it's sort of the general idea of what. This is where this goes. So let's just share my, let's just share this window. Still bad with sharing tools. So this is a, this is my job board scraper. Right.

Eric Zelman - **32:57**

So what this does is it takes my personal lens and scrapes all these different job boards, many of which that I think are garbage. Right. But that it comes back and it says, would I fit this role? And it's going to tell me about the company. It's going to have all the URLs, but it's also going to tell me about the funding cycle of that company.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **33:16**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **33:17**

You know, it's going to look the company up, it's going to do understanding of the job role. Is it a builder or maintainer role?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **33:25**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **33:25**

Because it knows that I'm interested in being a builder versus an inheritor.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **33:30**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **33:30**

Right. I don't, you know, I, I just don't want to be in a. I mean, I, I need a job. So I don't want to rule everything out. So I don't want it too narrow. I'm too myopic. But it knows that my ideal things that would be like green would be like a company looking for someone to build out customer support or ideally, you know, customer success in that kind of early stage. And again, job boards aren't probably worth the value is for me, this table here is where I've done the most work, where this comes off of about 30 different VC portfolios. And this is where the real value for me is it's gone through all of these startups. It scraped all of them it tells me about funding as much as it can.

Eric Zelman - **34:13**

I mean, you know, look, if I had money for Crunchbase, I'd buy it, but I don't. So I have, you know, my enrichment of my data may not be as great as what, you know, someone doing sales pipelines would want, but it's, it's, I think there. And, and also then it builds out the customer Persona for me so I can understand what kind of company I'm looking at and who, what their go to market strategy is going to be like.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **34:38**

Right, okay, cool.

Eric Zelman - **34:40**

And so I think that another aspect to what this is figuring out is would this be a useful tool? And this is a very narrow focus. Right. So one of the people that I have, I've asked to test this is not this pipeline, particularly here, but this tool in general is Ravi, because he's looking at customer success at early stage companies.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **35:03**

And is Robbie gone? He's gone, right?

Eric Zelman - **35:05**

Yeah, yeah. He, he resigned actually.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **35:08**

He, I thought so. I think he resigned just before I, I, I think while I was still there, but as I was phasing out. Okay.

Eric Zelman - **35:14**

Yeah. And I think that he's a perfect test candidate for this.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **35:19**

Yes.

Eric Zelman - **35:20**

But there's all kinds of people. So the next thing that I want to show you is that this is what stage one looks like. So stage one for me is validating the build of the personal narrative that through.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **35:34**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **35:34**

Before anyone has access to Here's 100 Startups or Here's a thousand scrapers or any of that stuff, that's much, much, much later if that happens.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **35:44**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **35:44**

I want to validate can I build lens documents that reflect people's mission and values and careers and then can I build scoring models off of it? That's really like, that's the sort of core atomic thing. And like I said, the next step, or one of the next steps is saying, can I do the companion piece on the other side and work with a company to model what it would look like as a lens to interrogate a thousand candidates or 100 candidates or whatever it is. Is this visible? Is this too small?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **36:17**

Yes, I just had to brighten my screen to just see it better. But yes, this is great.

Eric Zelman - **36:21**

Okay, so this leads a user to about a 45 minute discovery.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **36:27**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **36:28**

I'm building more guardrails because I don't want AI to drag people into full psychotherapy mode where it just goes on for hours and it will, so that's something. But basically here I'm going to go and I'm going to upload my resume and I'm gonna upload a resume. I might upload, you know, like PDFs, or I'll go here and I'll upload writing samples or maybe disk assessments. I could upload pictures. You know, I've just encourage people to put whatever they feel like it's valuable to them. Writing samples.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **37:00**

And like, none of the, and I mean, aside from resume, none of the fields are necessarily required. Right. Like, for example, like writing samples. For me, like, I have, I, I've written multiple things, but I haven't saved pretty. You know what I'm saying? So, like, for me, I don't know what I even would put there. So I'm just curious.

Eric Zelman - **37:17**

Yeah, no, it's really flexible. It's not required. They're just, they're just suggestions. And I also think that because of the way this is built, frankly, if you just dumped everything into one of these sections called writing samples, I don't think it knows the difference between, like, I don't think it cares. These are just four. These are just, it's just a form, but the data all goes to the same place.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **37:36**

Understood. Okay, cool.

Eric Zelman - **37:37**

So it's like, you know, if your resume, if you screenshotted your resume, it would think it was a resume versus a photo. It doesn't really differentiate. And I also think another cool place this could go is that, you know, for some people, this might be like, I want to upload my TED Talk or I want to upload audio or.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **37:53**

I want to upload. Exactly. Or podcast. I did. Or what have you.

Eric Zelman - **37:57**

Yeah, yeah. And that would all go into it too. And I think that would be, that would enrich things quite a bit. So then what happens is that they, you know, come in, they fill up this thing. They might, you know, I think that there's an opportunity for this for people who are already employed, who are looking in the background. I mean, I know some people are unhappy with the roles they're in, you know.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **38:19**

Yeah, that's right. 100.

Eric Zelman - **38:21**

So this could just go on and just sort of occasionally do searches for them, but it could also help them figure out more if they're through on, you know, so. And then pronouns, because I found that AI and haven't really gotten it to the point where it's always 100%, sometimes it's screwed up, and then I'm going to say I'm actively searching and then it's going to go and go through Several steps. Right. So each of these modules might take ideally five to eight minutes somewhere in there.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **38:55**

But.

Eric Zelman - **38:55**

Okay, I've told people if it starts to get long in the tooth after five minutes and you're frustrated, just tell it to move on.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **39:02**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **39:02**

Because Ravi said the other day in one of the builds he worked on, it took him like, you know, well over an hour. And I, I want to keep it manageable for people for sure. You know, again, I've spent months in coaching sass, that slash therapy. So. So like what, Rich to me might be different from rich to someone else.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **39:22**

Right, exactly. No, that's so true.

Eric Zelman - **39:24**

You know, and so you have to figure that out. But I, I don't know. So I don't want to make it ultimately endlessly open ended. Right. And so then they go to this discovery process and the chat bot takes in their content and starts to talk to them about their career.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **39:41**

This is awesome.

Eric Zelman - **39:42**

Now I don't want to drag us through going through this for a long period of time.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **39:46**

No, I get it. I know.

Eric Zelman - **39:47**

Okay, so then what happens is I built in a little quick thing so I can skip to the end and then what it's going to do is

it's going to take all that stuff and it's going to build out a document, it's going to build a PDF, but it's also capable, although I didn't implement it in this, of taking everything that goes into what you're about to see in this PDF and building it into a document that has a whole lot of scoring variables in it that could be used in that kind of pipeline that was showing so that it's not just prose and we'll see that. Hopefully we'll be done in a minute. Claude, you know, hopefully is not having an outage. And, and so then it comes up with this long synthesized document of all those materials put together.

Eric Zelman - **40:37**

My essence about my career, what I'm looking for and you know who I am, right? This, this identity skills, experience.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **40:49**

Yeah. Is there any other tools out here, like out there like this at the moment that you know of?

Eric Zelman - **40:54**

No.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **40:55**

This is really like from a recruiting standpoint, from a recruiting lens, this insight is incredible.

Eric Zelman - **41:03**

And yeah, so I, so no, I don't. So I'm not aware of them. So I've been doing so. So a couple of things have happened. So one is I did a bunch of different AI searches, patent searches and think competitive analysis searches across different platforms using like Claude, Perplexity, OpenAI, Gemini and I have them fight each Other kind of to figure out because I just don't trust that I think they're all trying to tell me it's a great idea because they're so sycophantic, you know. But what I found so far really is that there really isn't anything out in the market like this and that no one's patented this idea of this bi directional signal matching between customer or between candidate and company. So I went and filed a provisional patent on it as well to kind of protect that math.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **41:54**

Good for you. That's super smart.

Eric Zelman - **41:56**

And trying to also create an. I filed for an LLC this week so I can also try to try get some funding and grants on this. But in the competitive space. There is a company in a startup in the UK called Jack and Jill and Jack and Jill is an amazing job finder, I will give it that. And it's AI driven and it's very similar to this except that it's also very superficial. And so what Jack and Jill does is it lets you upload your resume and maybe like a short one page document.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **42:32**

Just write that down. Because I should check it out, right? Should I check it out?

Eric Zelman - **42:36**

And I use Jack and Jill to apply for jobs. I mean like I'm totally using it to get a gig and I want to see it work because like I think Jack and Jill is the nearest neighbor competitor. And Jack and Jill and David laughed at this because he thinks that anytime someone says they got any money it's bullshit because he knows how to bullshit. He knows the game, right? So Jack and Jill claims that they got 20 million in seed round like in December. So someone supposedly is spending money on these kinds of tools. But it doesn't create a personal document like this, it doesn't or anything they can export and it doesn't have any kind of interface for certainly the kind of VC scraping or any of that.

Eric Zelman - **43:16**

But, but when it goes to just sort of searching for jobs, it doesn't have the idea. I mean it's a conversational chatbot. Right. You know, like it's, it does things very generally. It also does things generally in a kind of classic chatbot startup way like if you upload code samples, it'll tell you where the code is wrong. Right. It's not really, it's not very well tuned.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **43:41**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **43:41**

But they have a lot of money and I'm just one person. So you know, again, David thinks that within six months all this will be wiped out because the next version of all these LLMs will just build all this automatically. And you know.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **43:54**

Yeah, he, I get it. That's kind of his lens.

Eric Zelman - **43:57**

His lens, his lens. Is that, is that building software is dead.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **44:02**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **44:04**

So where I'm going with this is that I don't think that there are competitors to this. There was a company that, I can't remember the name, but there was a company that tried to do this in the pre AI world to a point. They didn't patent anything. They were, they had like 20 or 30 million in startup or in a, a, a round stuff, maybe around 20, 20, somewhere just around the pandemic. And they collapsed. They got, they didn't get very far. Right. You know, Claude was like, you should really go talk to their founder to learn like what went wrong. So. And they weren't predicated also on this idea of building a lens for the company. It was, it wasn't clear, you know, that they had that kind of thing. So. So I think what I fleshed out so far is pretty unique.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **45:07**

Absolutely. Absolutely. Just by the looks of this.

Eric Zelman - **45:13**

Yeah. So then I guess my. What are my questions, Jen? So what do you think I should do? Who do you think I should talk to about this? How do you.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **45:23**

If so, I am.

Eric Zelman - **45:25**

Yeah.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **45:26**

Yeah. So my only. This is my. Like I've been thinking as you've been showing me this, so here's a couple of questions for you. So I'm say I'm the candidate, right. I want, I'm applying to jobs. It's stressful. Like, is this something they can do once? Like, is this something they can do once? And then use the, this, like sort of this assessment of Jen Monkowitz or Eric Zellman and share it with. Okay, cool. Because to me, like recruiters, like I say I'm a recruiter for Showpad, I'm not going to likely send this survey to each applicant because ultimately it's probably a bit lengthy. And you know how candidates don't like it. I mean, truly, sometimes if I see a lengthy process even to apply to a role, like go to our website and enter each job manually, I'm like, I'm out.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **46:16**

Do you know what I'm saying? So, like, that's my only question to you. Like, is it something that I go on your site? I do. I'm out of work or in transition or I'm still just simply not happy where I'm at. I kind of do this assessment and then I share that with employers.

Eric Zelman - **46:31**

I think it's a great question. So I mean, one of the questions I have, my feedback form is, would you share this with recruiter? Right. Is this quality is the thing that you got out of this? You know, when you get to the end and you make your PDF, the feedback form that I send to people, this thing here, one of the questions is, you know, would you share this with a recruiter?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **46:52**

Right, right.

Eric Zelman - **46:53**

I think that, you know, one of the other taglines I thought about this was that when you build this portfolio, I mean, again, this is very pie in the sky, but if you build it with sincere reflection on Eric and Jen's careers.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **47:07**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **47:07**

Who they are, it's the indelible you. It isn't the ATS optimized you.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **47:11**

That's right. That's right.

Eric Zelman - **47:13**

And I think that that authenticity, that indelible, you know, solidness is the value point for the job seeker.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **47:23**

Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **47:23**

And, but I also think they're going to people who are like, I don't want them to see my weaknesses. I don't want to, you know, present Eric as, you know, like, it's like a disc assessment. Eric just wants to have everything in D, you know, or Eric is alpha or whatever, you know, and I think that there's that tendency of people to kind of recoil, pull back and do that. So I don't know that everyone is going to just be like, oh my God, I can just be my authentic self now and send this to a recruiter. And the recruiter is going to show the company. The company's going to be like, thank you for showing your authentic self. You know, and I think that, that hiring a company, hiring someone, giving this to them, it's an open question.

Eric Zelman - **48:06**

And so I think that one of the disconnects that I have to sort of wrestle with is how do you productize this? Like, is this a free tool that I just put out in the world? Right. For people who are trying to figure out how do I find that through line and is the real business part of this for me or potential for this product? The other, the other side, it's not the candidate side, but the employer side. It's the employer side.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **48:38**

It's. That's where I think it's right. I think it's super benefit beneficial to a candidate. However, I think you to your point, I think it's more, I think you'll probably get more usage on the employer side for internal mobility. That's where I think like, in terms of like for you to actually Sell the product. Yeah, that's my opinion. But tell me if I'm wrong, are you leaning more toward that as well?

Eric Zelman - **49:02**

I mean, those are the signals I'm getting so far.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **49:05**

Yeah, yeah, for sure. I can see that. And, like, I think it's super beneficial for internal mobility. I think this is more in depth than, say, PI, because. PI, like, to your point, you say you can totally, like, gear it toward you what you think the. Of course you can. What you think the answer should be. I think this is more authentic based upon background and skills.

Eric Zelman - **49:28**

Yeah. And, you know, from the employer side also, I mean, not to. Not to put people in the box, but, like, you. You can, you know, things about the employee, good or bad, that you can put in here and pro and sort of create this profile and, you know, you can ask the employee to do it themselves. But I mean, as the employer, like, you know, you have access to their. To their performance reports. You have access to their history, their work histories and things like that. And so it's easier to digest what are Eric's strengths and weaknesses from that perspective than. Than, you know, just from Eric sending his resume or knowing Eric's been at Victingham for 13 years. I mean, I don't. Look, I don't want to. I mean, you know, David warned me about going down these roads. He's like.

Eric Zelman - **50:14**

He's like, you know, Eric, companies right now will spend, Are given license, spend whatever they want on. On AI, but it has to come out of HR's budget.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **50:23**

That's right. He's right.

Eric Zelman - **50:25**

So. So I'm like, you know, I don't. I don't want to. Also, I want to be careful about, you know, the ideas of how these tools work, because, I mean, someone will do it whether I do it or not. But. But, you know, I also don't want to create dystopian work environments where people are like, well, the bot said I was a good fit for this, or the bot screwed my career. You know, like, you don't want that.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **50:46**

Exactly.

Eric Zelman - **50:47**

You don't want that. And. But I do think that there are. Yeah, I think that on the internal mobility side, this would be really valuable. I wish I had this. And not only do I wish I had opportunities of people that were on my team, but, I mean, first and foremost, but I wish I did have this, as at the times where I had, you know, like, you know, 10 people on the L1 team or whatever, because I knew them really well, but I didn't know them that well. And this Would have been a really fascinating tool to understand, you know, like how they worked. Because again, in my ideal vision of the last 13 years, I would have thought, okay, maybe there's a point for them to move somewhere else within the company. But it didn't materialize.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **51:29**

Yeah, no, it makes total sense. Absolutely. I think half of the issue is that even at Big Tin can that we had is were trying to get managers to really understand the dynamics of people on their team. But David has such a, it's a slippery slope with budget. Right. HR is, was, is. We were always limited what we could do and what our budget was even at a fairly established organization. But then, you know, then you get these startups. So I think my, I mean, I'm thinking just, I don't know, would you have, would you initially maybe price it low as it rolls out and then I don't know how you'd even price it out at this point by user. Have you thought about that? I know maybe I'm rushing ahead.

Eric Zelman - **52:13**

I haven't really gotten to that yet. Yeah, I mean David thinks that again. And this is the David Lens. The David Lens is that Eric goes out in the world and uses this tool, a tool like this with companies that have no idea how to implement AI strategies. Right. Like he doesn't know, I mean, he didn't know that. He doesn't know if this company has this problem. But you know, he was saying like a company like Brookdale, they could, you know, he, in his mind they would never build this for themselves.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **52:42**

Right.

Eric Zelman - **52:42**

As a consultant, you could come in and implement something like this. And so it might also be that this is consultant driven. In talking todd, the career coach that I've worked with for a while, the more corporate guy, he'd love to partner on this. I haven't really figured how that's going to work. But you know, he has a lot of C level healthcare executives that he works with. People who are actually, you know, employed, not just the job seekers. I was kind of like. And, and you know, he's like, this could be a great tool for them. So I think that there's also an opportunity maybe for where consultancy on this tool isn't just me, but it's a coach or someone working with an HR department to build this out.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **53:27**

Right. For. And you know, another thing to think of, like you just sort of kind of, I think that's what you were getting at. But like this could be used for leadership Development. Right. For not only for internal mobility, but it, but definitely for, I mean, even like leadership development for sure is where I see it being a huge benefit.

Eric Zelman - **53:46**

What the, the ex Goldman person put me or putting me in touch with is she has a friend, another friend from Goldman who started this. I don't. I forget her company, but so she does. Her whole firm is recruiting for executive boards, for board recruitment and so.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **54:07**

Okay.

Eric Zelman - **54:07**

And so Edie thought this would be an amazing tool for building out board member profiles.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **54:12**

Absolutely, Absolutely. I love it. I love it. And if I can, you know, if I can help in any way, you know that I'm here. I mean, I, so I'm. I actually just, I just got myself registered for an LLC and I got my tax ID number and I think my next venture will be fractional interim HR work. I met someone actually through Vector who was. We had. They had flown the h. The you know, chief people, officers and CFO out to Dallas back last May when they were still nice to us. And I met a girl there that was in their portfolio and she does just 20 hours a week for a company in their portfolio. And then she started her business.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **54:58**

So I'm working to support her and then I'm hoping to get my, you know, work with other fractional HR companies where I can just basically build my own book of business. So I'm. This tool, to me is awesome and I'm happy to help in any way I can promote it, etc.

Eric Zelman - **55:15**

No, I, I love the support and I, I'd love to figure out a way to collaborate together and to, you know, to, you know, find a way for this to scale up. Right. And to prove the point. And as I go forward, I mean, I'll definitely include you and reach out to you again because I would love to show you the next steps of, you know, the lens from the company side where I, you know, kind of create this hypothetical maybe big tin can clone or not.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **55:47**

No, absolutely. I love it.

Eric Zelman - **55:49**

And take a look at it from, you know, the other way around and figure out, you know, what. How would a go to market strategy for a tool like this work? How. How does Eric make this into something that, you know, gets some revenue back?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **56:03**

Absolutely. Absolutely. No, this is great. And again, if I think of anything along the way, I'll reach out to you. I don't know if I think I have your. No, I think I have your email now that you sent me the invite. So I have your email, I believe now you're so.

Eric Zelman - **56:17**

I can reach out, but it's just Zelmanage Gmail, so.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **56:20**

Perfect. Yeah.

Eric Zelman - **56:22**

Yeah. So thank you so much for your time and of course.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **56:25**

No, that's great.

Eric Zelman - **56:26**

Oh, you know, last but not least, here, I'll throw you off. I'll drag you into this. If you're willing, I'd love to ask you if you could be a tester so I can send you access and put aside maybe about an hour. Remember, if the bot starts to drag you into. Tell us about your childhood. You know, like, just like, no, next. You know, like so. And then at the end of it, give some feedback about, you know, does this. Is this. You know, what is. What was the experience like for you?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **56:54**

I will. I would love to. I'd love to test it and be it. You know, I would. I'll absolutely do that.

Eric Zelman - **56:59**

I love that. And, and if you think of other people who also would be valuable testers, like, I'm really happy that you and I spoke. I wasn't sure, you know, I could ask Danielle. I don't, you know, I didn't reach out to her about this.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **57:11**

I mean, you absolutely could. I think Danielle's great, but I think she's. Yeah, I would ask her. I can't see why you couldn't. Yeah, I think she's in the weeds with the folks at Showpad, but I would, I, I'm sure she would do it to help you out.

Eric Zelman - **57:25**

I, I, you know, I, I think the more people I can get in the people and culture and recruiting space, it seems like that's going to be a really fertile place to get feedback from.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **57:38**

Absolutely. It really is. I love it. You know, and another person, I. Probably not. I was going to say another person could be Mike Tuohy, who helped us from a contract recruiting standpoint, but Mike.

Eric Zelman - **57:48**

I thought about Mike yesterday.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **57:49**

Yeah, he's good. He's good, but he's just. I had to explain this, and this is not an insult. He's just strictly a recruiter. I don't know that he has like that. I don't know.

Eric Zelman - **58:03**

No, and I think you're right. I mean, I think Mike. Mike is like, I have my customers. I do this for some amount of time.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **58:10**

That's right.

Eric Zelman - **58:10**

You know, and then, you know, he's, He's. He. Mike buys and flips houses. That's how he makes.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **58:16**

That's his cool guy. And I think very highly of. But I don't know that it's his wheelhouse. I think that Danielle would be a better person. And I know that she. I. I mean, you know her well enough, too. I think she would. I personally think she would very much want to help if she can, but I know she's in the weeds, so maybe even if you just say, you know, when you have some time.

Eric Zelman - **58:34**

Yeah, yeah, No, I know. She's very, like. She's been super helpful with all the confusion about health care.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **58:43**

Yes. She's awesome afterwards.

Eric Zelman - **58:45**

And so she's. She's great. And she probably has her up to her eyeballs, and all of us asking her for, like, what is up with bcbs? What happened to this change? Why is this, you know?

Jenn Monkiewicz - **58:55**

I know, Absolutely. I get it. But look, I. I think this is awesome. I definitely will. Will do that for you, and I'd love to just continue, like, let's continue to keep in touch, because maybe we can, at some point, partner. I don't know.

Eric Zelman - **59:08**

Yeah, no, yeah, I'd love that. And. And, you know, because for real, like, as you. As you look at this and you're like, oh, I have this idea, or this could go somewhere. Like, you know, the. It. It's. It's super valuable. And. And I want to build this out. I want to, you know, find ways to get this into the marketplace. So it's like, you know, if you find a company or you have friends or colleagues or, you know, just along the way who are receptive to this or you see opportunities, I'd love to partner with people to make it happen.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **59:37**

Absolutely. You got it.

Eric Zelman - **59:40**

Awesome. Thank you so much.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **59:42**

Thank you, Eric. And I'll. Let's. Let's keep in touch. Great.

Eric Zelman - **59:45**

Take care.

Jenn Monkiewicz - **59:46**

Bye. Bye.